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Russia's Tactical Nuclear Threshold: Low, Rising, and Concentrated Where Battlefield Reversal Meets Regime Stress

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BOTTOM LINE

A 3-6% chance in twelve months is a low probability. For battlefield nuclear use, it is not a small one.

NERAI assesses Russian tactical nuclear use within 12 months at 3-6% - a structured, low-confidence estimate whose derivation we publish rather than hide. That is roughly an order of magnitude above any pre-2022 baseline, and the risk is not spread evenly: it concentrates in one cell of the scenario grid, where a major battlefield reversal compounds with a genuine regime-survival shock (15-30% in that branch). Internal strain - a persisting fuel crisis, eroding public patience, falling approval - is real and worsening, but it is a conditional multiplier, not an independent path: nothing in the current record shows elite fracture or a leadership that perceives existential threat.

EXECUTIVE TAKEAWAYS

THE QUIET INDICATOR - Open sources show no evidence of large-scale growth in warheads assigned to non-strategic roles (~1,794 per FAS 2026). Production rate unknown - and with ~1,800 already in inventory, stockpile stasis says little about limited-use intent.

THE MOVING INDICATOR - The unannounced 19-21 May 2026 exercise combined strategic and non-strategic forces across ~65,000 troops and, for the first time on film, rehearsed physical transfer of (dummy) warheads to a Belarusian Iskander unit. Rehearsal is not enactment - it is capability practice.

THE MISREAD INDICATOR - Russia's November 2024 doctrine keeps release authority with the President alone. Claims of pre-delegation to field commanders circulate; the published text contains none.

THE HONEST NUMBER - Every probability in this brief is a labelled analyst judgment with its assumptions table in the full version - including the one assumption nobody can measure: the probability that strain becomes shock.

FIVE INDICATORS, ONE READING

Indicator	Status (Aug 2026)	What would change our mind
Warhead production	No evidence of large-scale increase; rate unknown	Reversal of the flat non-strategic trend
Custody & movement	No observed movement of real warheads; transfer procedure rehearsed in May with Belarus	Verified 12th GUMO movement outside exercise context; visual confirmation in Belarus
Exercises	Institutionalizing: 2024 joint series to unannounced combined May 2026 drill	TNW play moving from announced choreography to no-notice readiness tests
Rhetoric	Elevated plateau; volume historically inverse to real readiness	Presidential-level statement naming a specific, imminent condition
Context triggers	Converging slowly: deep strikes reach Moscow's fuel supply; internal strain accumulating	A second mobilization decree; elite-coercion cascade; regime treating losses as existential

THE SCENARIO GRID

12-month scenario	Probability	TNW risk
A - Grinding continuation	50-60%	1-3% (4-8% if an internal shock lands)
B - Freeze / negotiated pause	15-20%	under 1%
C - Major Russian reversal	12-18%	8-15% (15-30% when reversal and regime stress compound)
D - Russian strategic success	8-16%	under 1%
Weighted overall	100%	~3-6% - low confidence, derivation in the full version

Why Scenario A matters most: by weight of probability, the grinding branch carries the largest single share of total nuclear risk. The dramatic scenario makes headlines; the compound path - slow failure plus internal rupture - gives less warning.

WHAT WE WATCH WEEKLY

1. 12th GUMO warhead movements outside exercise context - the line between rehearsal and enactment (highest diagnostic value).
2. Belarus custody: visual confirmation of warheads, not infrastructure; readiness of the Iskander units drilled in May.
3. The North Korean ladder: activation of the reported Voronezh missile unit; the claimed 30,000-strong follow-on tranche - flagged explicitly as Ukrainian intelligence via Reuters, not independently verified.
4. Mobilization signals: legislative preparation, conscription changes, call-up infrastructure.
5. Elite coercion: NERA's confiscate-property index sits at its 98th historical percentile, +53 versus its 90-day mean - the regime pricing its own instability.
6. Fiscal and fuel markers: refining capacity (the record ~17% idled dates to August 2025 - the crisis persists into August 2026), National Wealth Fund drawdown, rationing spread.
7. Decision-maker rhetoric specificity - named conditions with timelines from the President or Security Council; we discount commentary-class noise to zero.
8. Deep-strike drift toward strategic-force-adjacent assets - the inadvertent-escalation channel the 2026 US threat assessment flags.

METHOD, IN ONE PARAGRAPH

This brief distils a full analyst report built on NERA's daily 60-country risk indices, regime-state models and a two-axis scenario framework (battlefield x internal regime stress), cross-read against August 2026 open reporting - each claim carrying its source and date, single-origin claims labelled as such, and every probability presented as a structured judgment with its assumptions table. The full version includes the derivation, the counter-thesis we take seriously (the coercive-theatre school), five stated intelligence gaps, and a 28-entry bibliography.

Full analyst version - Russia-Ukraine War Trajectory: Major Offensive & Tactical Nuclear Risk Assessment (10 pages, scenarios, derivation tables, bibliography) - available at neraia.com/foresight-desk. Analyst contact: kagan@neraia.com

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